announcing the construction of a Hindu temple in Abu Dhabi, the first in the Gulf region.

During his Pacific Islands trip in November 2014, the first visit by an Indian prime minister in over three decades, Modi announced the setting up of a $1 million fund and visa on arrival facility for Indians settled in Fiji and other islands. In an attempt to boost trade with these islands New Delhi will set up a trade office and also raise the annual grant-in-aid for community projects to each Pacific Island country from $125,000 annually to $200,000.[14]

Subsequently, at the second Forum of India–Pacific Islands Cooperation (FIPIC) held in Jaipur on 22 August 2015, Modi pitched for stronger cooperation with the fourteen islands by offering to set up an Institute for Sustainable Coastal and Ocean Research, provide naval support for coastal surveillance and hydrographic surveys as well as set up Space Technology Application Centres in these island nations.[15]

China is both a major trading partner and a potential competitor for India. On his first trip to China as prime minister in May 2015, Modi spoke of the ‘ancient spiritual and cultural links’ shared by the two countries. He emphasized that India’s ties with China are one of its most important strategic partnerships as the ‘re-emergence of India and China and their relationship will have a profound impact on the two countries and the course of this century’.[16] In a speech before twenty-two top Chinese CEOs, Modi pitched his ‘Make in India’ agenda and during his trip twenty-one business agreements were signed worth US $22 billion. Modi sought investment in India’s infrastructure plans – from railways, to highways to road and port building – emphasizing that India had changed and was now ‘more transparent, responsive and stable’.[17]

Among world leaders, Modi has a close personal relationship with Japanese prime minister Shinzo Abe, who like Modi is a centre-right nationalist politician attempting to revive his country’s economy,